Leading Through Change - Study guide

Leader course | Trainer: Maya Thompson

About this guide

Help your team understand, shape and commit to change instead of enduring it.

These notes follow the video lecture for this course. Read them before or after watching, and use them to revise before the final quiz.

What you will be able to do

- Explain the why of a change in plain language

- Spot and address resistance early

- Keep momentum after the launch

Change from the team’s point of view

- Change is usually done to people

- Uncertainty feels like a threat

- Resistance is information

Welcome to Leading Through Change. When an organisation changes, leaders often see an opportunity, while the people affected see uncertainty. They wonder what happens to their role, their routine and their team. That difference in view explains most of the friction. In this lecture we will look at why people resist change, how to explain the reason for it in plain language, how to spot resistance early, and how to keep momentum going after the launch, which is where many programmes quietly fade.

Why people resist change

- They expect to lose something

- They do not understand the reason

- They doubt it will be seen through

Resistance is usually information. People resist when they expect to lose something, such as status, familiar routines or relationships. They resist when they do not understand why the change is happening, so it feels arbitrary. And they resist when they have seen earlier changes started and abandoned, so they doubt this one will

last. If you treat resistance as an attitude problem, you will argue. If you treat it as information, you will ask what the person expects to lose, and that is a far more useful conversation.

Talking about loss honestly

- Name what will change

- Name what will stay the same

- Do not pretend there is no cost

Being honest about loss builds credibility. If a team will lose a familiar process, say so. If some roles will look different, say so. People can cope with bad news far better than with the sense that something is being hidden. Equally important is saying what will not change, because that gives people something stable to stand on. Avoid selling the change as purely positive. A balanced message, this will be harder for a while, here is why it is worth it, and here is how we will support you, is both truthful and reassuring.

The change story

- Where we are

- Where we are going and why

- What will not change

A change story is a short, honest narrative that you can repeat. It has three parts. First, where we are now, including what is not working. Second, where we are going and why, in plain language a new starter would understand. Third, what will not change, such as your values or your commitment to people. Write it in a few sentences, test it on someone outside the project, and remove any jargon. A good test is whether a team member could retell it to a colleague after hearing it once. If they cannot, simplify it.

Spotting resistance early

- Silence in meetings

- Quiet workarounds

- Questions that circle back to the old way

Resistance rarely announces itself. Look for silence in meetings where you expected questions. Look for quiet workarounds, where people keep using the old process alongside the new one. Notice questions that keep returning to how things used to work. When you see these signs, do not push harder. Ask openly, what is making this difficult, and listen without defending. Often the problem is practical, a missing tool, a gap in training, or an unclear role. Fixing a practical barrier early is much cheaper than overcoming a hardened position later.

Keeping momentum after launch

- Make progress visible

- Celebrate small wins

- Build short regular check-ins

Most change efforts fade after the launch. Energy drops, attention moves on, and old habits return. To keep momentum, make progress visible. A simple board or a short update each week shows people that the change is real. Celebrate small wins, because they prove the direction is right. And build regular check-ins into the calendar where people can say what is working and what is not. Small rituals, repeated, do more than a big launch event. The goal is for the new way to become the normal way, and that takes repetition.

Your role as the leader

- Be consistent in what you say and do

- Stay visible during the hard weeks

- Ask for feedback and act on it

People watch what leaders do more closely than what they say. If you announce a new way of working and then use the old one yourself, the message is lost. Be consistent. Stay visible during the difficult weeks, rather than disappearing once the plan is approved. And ask for feedback on how the change is landing, then visibly act on at least some of it. When people see that their input changes something, they move from

watching the change to taking part in it. That shift is what turns compliance into commitment.

Your next steps

- Write your change story in five sentences

- List the likely losses and your response

- Complete the workbook and the final quiz

To finish, write your change story in no more than five sentences and test it on one person. List the losses your team may feel and how you will respond to each. Complete the workbook for this course, which has a template for the change story and a resistance map. Then take the final quiz. When you finish the last lesson, you will receive your certificate and a personal review of your progress. Change is hard for everyone involved, and your steadiness as a leader makes a real difference.

Glossary

Resistance: A response to change that signals an expected loss, a lack of understanding or a lack of trust.

Change story: A short honest narrative covering where we are, where we are going and what will not change.

Workaround: A way of doing something that quietly avoids the new process.

Momentum: The sense that progress is real and continuing after the launch.